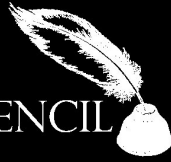


THE *Noir* PENCIL



CHICAGO · EST. 2016 · FOUNDED FOR EVERY WRITER

Which Edit Do You Need?

*A guide to understanding proofreading, line editing,
and developmental editing. How to find the right fit.*

TNP

Honest. Clear. Built for every writer.

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Before We Start

Most writers know their writing needs something. They just are not always sure what. And nobody really teaches you the difference between proofreading, line editing, and developmental editing, or how to know which one your document actually needs right now.

That is what this guide is for. Not to overwhelm you with editorial terminology, but to help you see your document more clearly and walk away with a confident sense of what the right next step actually is.

You will find a description of each service, what it does and does not address, and who it is best for. There are also notes specifically for ESL writers and resume clients, since those documents come with their own set of questions.

At the end, there is a short decision prompt to help you land on the right service. And if you are still unsure after reading through everything, you can send your document directly and I will tell you exactly where it stands.

Come as you are.

“Say exactly what you mean. We will handle the rest.”

· The Noir Pencil

Proofreading

Proofreading is the final step. It is a surface-level pass over a document that is already complete, already organized, and already saying what you want it to say. At this stage, the writing is done. You are just making sure the mechanics are right before it goes anywhere.

Think of it as the polish, not the build. The structure is standing. The sentences are working. The content is where it needs to be. This is the step that makes sure nothing slipped through in the final stretch.

WHAT IT ADDRESSES

- Grammar and spelling errors
- Punctuation and capitalization
- Formatting consistency throughout the document
- Typos, repeated words, and minor mechanical errors

WHAT IT DOES NOT ADDRESS

Proofreading does not improve how your writing reads. It will not strengthen weak sentences, smooth out choppy flow, or reorganize your ideas. If your document has clarity issues, awkward phrasing, or structural problems, proofreading will not fix them. A proofread document still has to be a good document going in.

WHO IT IS BEST FOR

You have a strong draft. You have already revised it. You feel confident about the content and the structure, and you just want a professional eye on it before it goes out.

Also a good fit for ESL writers who are confident in their content and structure but want a final check on grammar and mechanics before submitting.

Line Editing

Line editing works at the sentence level. This is the edit that addresses how your writing reads: the flow, the rhythm, the clarity, the word choice. The content is there. The ideas are in place. But something is not quite landing the way you intended, and you can feel it even if you cannot name it.

This is the most common service writers need and the one most often confused with proofreading. The difference is depth. Proofreading corrects errors. Line editing improves the writing itself.

WHAT IT ADDRESSES

- Sentence clarity and how ideas are expressed
- Flow and rhythm from sentence to sentence
- Word choice and precision
- Tone consistency throughout the document
- Awkward or tangled phrasing
- Transitions between paragraphs and ideas

WHAT IT DOES NOT ADDRESS

Line editing works with the structure you have. It does not reorganize your document, rebuild your argument, or identify missing content. If the bigger picture needs work. If the bigger picture needs work, if sections feel out of order or the overall message is unclear, that is a developmental issue, not a sentence-level one.

WHO IT IS BEST FOR

Your document is mostly together. The ideas are there. But when you read it back, something feels off. The writing does not quite sound like you at your best. You want someone to work through it carefully and make it read the way you meant it to.

Also a strong fit for ESL writers who are solid in content but want their language to sound more natural and fluent in English. And for resume clients who want their experience to read more clearly and compellingly on the page.

Developmental Editing

Developmental editing addresses the big picture. This is the edit that looks at your document as a whole: what it is trying to say, how it is organized, whether the argument holds, and whether the reader can follow you from beginning to end.

It happens before the sentence-level work, because there is no point in polishing language that may need to move, change, or be cut entirely. Structure comes first. Everything else follows.

WHAT IT ADDRESSES

- Overall structure and organization
- Argument clarity and logical flow
- Pacing and how ideas build across the document
- Missing or underdeveloped sections
- Paragraph purpose and order
- The reader's experience from beginning to end

WHAT IT DOES NOT ADDRESS

Developmental editing is not a line edit and it is not a proofread. It focuses on what the document is doing, not on how individual sentences sound. Grammar and surface-level polish come after the structure is working. Those are separate steps.

WHO IT IS BEST FOR

You have been working on this document for a while. You have rewritten it more than once. Something still feels off about the whole thing. Not just a sentence here or there, but the overall shape of it. You are not sure if your argument is coming through, or you know the content is there but it is not organized in a way that is easy to follow.

Common Mistakes When Choosing an Editing Service

Choosing the wrong editing service is more common than you might think. It is not a reflection of your writing ability. It just happens when you are not sure what each service actually does. Here are the patterns that come up most often.

Submitting for proofreading when the document needs a line edit.

Proofreading corrects errors. It does not improve weak writing. If your sentences are unclear, your tone is off, or the writing feels flat, a proofread will not change that. A clean document is not the same as a strong one.

Expecting line editing to fix a structural problem.

If your document is disorganized, if the ideas are out of order, the argument is unclear, or whole sections are missing, a line edit will not solve it. Line editing works with the structure you have. If the structure needs work first, that is a developmental edit.

Expecting developmental editing to cover grammar.

Developmental editing focuses on the big picture. It does not function as a proofread. Grammar and mechanics come after the structure is in place, as a separate step.

A NOTE FOR ESL WRITERS

If you are writing in English as a second or additional language, you may be unsure whether your document needs proofreading or line editing. A good starting point: if your ideas feel clear to you but your sentences feel uncertain in English, a line edit is usually the better fit. Proofreading corrects errors. Line editing helps the language flow naturally around the ideas you already have.

A NOTE FOR RESUME AND CAREER DOCUMENT CLIENTS

If your resume is mostly complete and you want the language tightened and the bullet points strengthened, a line edit is the right service. If you are still shaping how your experience is presented: what to include, how to position yourself, how to frame a career shift. A developmental approach would serve you better.

Still Not Sure? Start Here.

Ask yourself these questions honestly. They will not give you a perfect answer every time, but they will get you close.

Do I feel confident about the overall structure and content?

If yes: your document probably does not need developmental editing. Move to the next question.

If no: start with developmental editing.

Does the writing flow well when I read it out loud?

If yes: proofreading is likely enough.

If no: a line edit would help.

Am I writing in English as a second or additional language?

A line edit is usually the better starting point, even if the document feels mostly complete.

Is this a resume or career document?

Line editing is the most common fit. Developmental editing if you are still shaping how your experience is presented.

Ready to move forward?

Send your document and I will take a look. I will tell you exactly where it stands and what it needs. No pressure, no commitment. Just a clear answer from someone who has read a lot of documents and knows what to look for.

Every kind of writer is welcome here. Whether you are a first-time writer or someone who has been doing this for years, whether English is your first language or your fifth, whether you are submitting something important or finally finishing something you have been putting off. I am glad you found us.

Send your document at thenoirpencil.com/inquire

Proofreading · Line Editing · Developmental Editing · Resume Editing



Ready for a second set of eyes?

This guide will take you far. But the strongest writing always benefits from an editor who reads carefully, edits intentionally, and protects what makes the writing yours.

Send your document when you are ready.

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